

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 362

By Crowe

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Steve Grindstaff of Elizabethton.

WHEREAS, it was with great sadness that we learned of the passing of Steve Grindstaff, a highly successful and colorful businessman who owned several motor vehicle dealerships in Elizabethton and Johnson City; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Grindstaff began working in motor vehicle sales as a young man and soon mastered the skills of satisfying customers and successfully operating a business; he took a major career step forward in 1987 when he acquired the Chevrolet dealership in Elizabethton; and

WHEREAS, an avid promoter of his dealership at a time when promotion was extremely important in the industry, Mr. Grindstaff took a prominent role in the dealership's advertising and soon adopted the nickname "The Boss"; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Grindstaff was renowned throughout Northeast Tennessee for his flamboyant, larger-than-life personality; applying these personal traits to his business life, he continuously expanded the size of his dealership, adding both acreage and vehicles, and began calling the property "Little Detroit"; and

WHEREAS, after acquiring a Chrysler dealership and a Ford dealership, Mr. Grindstaff was quite proud to have the three largest American automobile corporations represented and arranged side-by-side on the property; and

WHEREAS, he later built a Chevrolet and Cadillac dealership and Volkswagen, Subaru, and Kia dealerships in Johnson City and developed two additional Kia dealerships in Bristol and Kingsport, for a total of fourteen separate locations; and

WHEREAS, after touring Spain, Mr. Grindstaff was inspired to build his version of a Spanish castle on the shore of Boone Lake, and the finished product was a 19,000-square-foot mansion with eight bedrooms, ten bathrooms, a movie theater, a miniature version of Bristol Motor Speedway, and a fourteen-car garage; and

WHEREAS, after the house was destroyed by fire, he, undeterred by the horrific experience and the enormous task of replacing the edifice, rebuilt the mansion in just a few years; and

WHEREAS, possessing a "heart as big as the ocean," Mr. Grindstaff remained a major force for good in the community after stepping back from a busy and hectic life in business and became active in charitable events and programs supporting education; and

WHEREAS, Steve Grindstaff evidenced "enormous love" for his family and encouraged their work in support of worthy civic and charitable causes; and

WHEREAS, he is survived by his wife, Ashley Martin Grindstaff; children, Baron Edward Grindstaff, Bentley Steven Grindstaff, Steven Edward Grindstaff II, Renee Grindstaff Mullins, and Amie Grindstaff Markland; sons-in-law, Adam Mullins and Jeff Markland; grandchildren, Adam Steven Mullins and his fiancée, Margret Delaney Walsh, Chandlor Storm Mullins, Zeth Christian Mullins, Landon Keith Pearson, and Stephaine Pearson Pastella and her husband, Devon Pastella; and a great-granddaughter, Winsley Clover Pearson; and

WHEREAS, Steve Grindstaff is fondly remembered by Senator Rusty Crowe and friends like Laura and Alan Levine as "a great American patriot and proud Tennessean, hugely successful businessman, entrepreneur, master salesman, proud father and husband, incredibly charitable and generous ... a great business leader and community partner"; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Steve Grindstaff of

Elizabethton, reflecting fondly upon his life of purpose and commitment to others and his excellence as a businessman, public servant, family man, and human being.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and extend our condolences to Mr. Grindstaff's family and many friends.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.